



TRACKING ATROCITIES

ONGOING HUMAN RIGHTS VIOLATIONS AMID CONFLICT IN ETHIOPIA

Documenting evidence to
trigger accountability

A CONTINUOUS MONITORING REPORT
July-September 2025



Organization for Justice &
Accountability
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TRACKING ATROCITIES: ONGOING HUMAN RIGHTS VIOLATIONS AMID CONFLICT IN ETHIOPIA

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY AND CALL TO ACTION

The report, covering the period from July to September 2025, confirms that the human rights crisis in Ethiopia is not only intensifying but also spreading to, at least, two additional regions, i.e., Amhara, Oromia. OJAH documented 39 new incidents of human right violation in the last three months. Unlawful killings remain the most frequent atrocity, with Ethiopian Government Forces still cited as the principal perpetrator. The data provides compelling evidence that civilians are harmed in nearly 90% of incidents. The majority of human rights violations committed by other actors are committed in the presence or close proximity of government security forces who turn a blind eye, suggesting a complete institutional decay and collapse. OJAH urgently calls for a decisive international response to investigate the situation, impose targeted sanctions on perpetrators of violence, and support schemes to solidify a unified advocacy and accountability strategy front outside of the radar of the government.



URGENT APPEAL FOR ACTION

- **Human Rights Advocacy Groups and Civil Society:** OJAH urges all organizations dedicated to justice and accountability in Ethiopia to join forces by establishing a Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations. This unified coalition should coordinate a victim-centered transitional justice process and pursue all possible legal measures to ensure justice and accountability.
- **International Community:** OJAH reiterate its request for partners to offer technical and financial assistance for forming the Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations so that the government’s tactical procrastination of justice and accountability can be averted.
- **Diplomatic pressure and targeted sanctions:** OAH calls for the international community to put genuine diplomatic pressure championing voiceless children, women, and senior citizens and strengthen the pressure through targeted sanctions against perpetrators of violence.
- **Ethiopian Justice and Security Bodies and Perpetrators:** OJAH demands that Ethiopian law enforcement agencies uphold due process of law and calls on all perpetrators to immediately stop violating human rights.

THE REPORT

This report presents the findings of the continuous monitoring phase conducted by OJAH, immediately following the foundational pilot project ("Leap of Insight" – January to June 2025). This phase monitored and analyzed 39 new human rights violations across four high-risk regions (Amhara, Oromia, Tigray, and Afar) during the three months of July 1 to September 30, 2025.

CONTEXT: TACTICAL PROCRASTINATION AS A POLITICAL GAME

The Ethiopian government has proposed several initiatives over the past seven years, ostensibly aiming at justice and accountability, yet strategically stalling while conflict continues to rage across different parts of the country. As one unfulfilled justice mechanism is replaced by another broken promise, the cycle of atrocities intensifies. The absence of concrete and meaningful justice and accountability measures has become the status quo, leaving millions of Ethiopians exposed to unspeakable abuses amid a deafening silence of the international community. Data from the last three months clearly show that this tactical procrastination by the government has opened the door to impunity, making violence against human rights the norm in Ethiopia and threatening the very fabric of social cohesion.

This deliberate obstructionism not only shows the unwillingness of the government to acknowledge past violations but an unnatural chilling drive to abandon its fundamental moral responsibility to prevent future atrocities. The persistent conflicts across the four monitored regions, marked by severe human rights abuses, clearly show that the government is in palsy unable to secure peace, stability, or justice. OJAH'S continuous monitoring provides proof on the prevailing impunity by generating real-time, verifiable evidence intended to support and strengthen external advocacy efforts.

METHOD

- **Geographic Expansion:** Monitoring expanded from two regions (Amhara and Tigray) to four high-risk regions: Amhara, Oromia, Tigray, and Afar. This scale-up involved training and deploying local documenters in Oromia and Afar.
- **Documentation efforts:** The data rely on human intelligence, open-source documentation, and media monitoring, all subjected to a rigorous, multi-layered verification process.
- **Ethical Standard:** OJAH operates under a strict "do no harm" principle, prioritizing the confidentiality and security of survivors and sources at all times.
- **System Enhancements:** Based on lessons learned in the pilot, the data collection tool was overhauled to minimize errors, formally integrating International Crime Indicators and establishing a formalized Three-Tiered Verification protocol for maximum evidence integrity.

OPERATIONAL LIMITATIONS

The monitoring phase identified critical operational challenges

- **Information Environment:** Inconsistent internet and communication blackouts routinely delay incident recording and submission.
- **Security Risks:** Local documenters face extreme danger, making information access and verification difficult in conflict zones.

FINDINGS: THE ESCALATION OF SYSTEMATIC VIOLENCE

OVERVIEW OF INCIDENTS AND ESCALATION

A total of **39 incidents** were recorded and analyzed in all the four regions: Tigray, Afar, Amhara, and Oromia. Violence is highly concentrated in the Amhara (**51.28%**) and the Oromia (**25.64%**) regions, together accounting for over three-quarters of all reported incidents. Incidents in Amhara peaked toward the end of the quarter, confirming high-intensity military operations, while Oromia's incidents were high early in the quarter, driven by systematic abduction campaigns.

Takeaway

Incidents of atrocities have spread across four regions, possibly foreshadowing a trend towards a geographic expansion of the conflict and ensuing human rights violations in the near future.

TYPES OF HUMAN RIGHT VIOLATIONS AND ATROCITY RISK

- **Unlawful killings:** constitute the single largest violation category at 46.15% of all incidents. Nine in ten (89.74%) incidents show evidence of targeting civilians.
- **Military-Grade Firepower:** The use of mortars, artillery, and drone attacks (15.38% of incidents), including an attack on a healthcare facility, confirms the government's use of remote and high-tech projectiles on civilians and civilian objects.
- **Violations of Liberty:** Abductions/Kidnappings (12.82%) remains a severe threat, particularly in Oromia, and is often linked to extortion making it unsafe to move few hundred miles outside of the capital city Addis Ababa.

Takeaway:

The use of lethal military force against civilians defines the conflict. Freedom of movement is endangered even in non-active conflict zones for fear of abductions and kidnappings.

ALLEGED PERPETRATORS

The Ethiopian government, entrusted with protecting civilians, is the principal perpetrator of atrocities. Though the security landscape is highly fluid the government and state-aligned regional forces have been found to be responsible for 64.11% of all incidents.

- **Ethiopian Government Forces (ENDF):** The ENDF remains the single most cited perpetrator, implicated in 35.90% of all recorded incidents. The government is linked to use of lethal military tactics which includes the use of mortars, artillery, and drone attacks on civilians.
- **State-Aligned Regional Forces:** Regional Militia (17.95%) and Regional Police Force (10.26%) collectively account for a significant portion of abuses, demonstrating that the violence is deeply embedded within state and state-affiliated security structures.

- **Non-State Armed Groups:** OJAH has identified three non-state actors as perpetrators:
 - **Oromo Liberation Army (OLA):** This group contributed 10.26% of the incidents. strongly linked to abduction/kidnapping and identity-based killings, particularly against children, women, and the elderly.
 - **Amhara Fano:** A non-state armed actor consistently linked to armed clashes and post-conflict summary killings was also responsible for 10.26% of the recorded incidents.
 - **Tigray Armed Force (TAF):** A non-state/regional force cited primarily in the Tigray region, similarly identified as perpetrator on 10.26% of the total recorded incidents.

Takeaway:

The Ethiopian government, entrusted with protecting civilians, is the principal perpetrator of atrocities and this is compounded by a significant portion of human rights violations committed by state-aligned regional forces exposing civilians to unspeakable abuses and trauma.

AFFECTED GROUPS: VICTIMS AND SURVIVORS

- No section of the society is immune to human rights violations, but women (41.03%) and children (30.77%) were heavily represented among victims/survivors. The OLA is implicated in harming women and children in nearly 100% of its recorded incidents. Victims/survivors also include health professionals, journalists, and local administrators targeted to dismantle essential services and civic life.

Takeaway:

No section of society is immune to human rights violations in Ethiopia, but women, children, and the elderly bear the greatest burden.

INSTITUTIONAL FAILURE TO PROTECT CIVILIANS

In 10.26% of cases involving high-impact attacks, security forces (including the ENDF and Federal Police) were documented as being present nearby but failing to intervene. In one case, forces reportedly advised witnesses that they should pay ransom after an abduction. This inaction is not mere incompetence; it suggests institutional negligence or possible complicity, providing armed groups the assurance that they can encroach upon human rights without consequence.

Takeaway:

The existing institutional negligence and potential collusion and with criminal armed groups suggests the possible proliferation of state-sponsored pillage and ransack which hinders the legitimacy of accountability efforts of the government.

TARGETED REPRESSION OF RIGHTS DEFENDERS AND PROFESSIONALS

OJAH has verified and documented attacks that obstructed humanitarian services and human rights monitoring. This includes:

- A drone attack on a healthcare facility which killed health workers and patients, while also destroying essential infrastructure.
- Threatening and detaining of Journalists while covering peaceful protests.
- Killing of court officials and local administrators with an intent to dismantle local governance structures.

Takeaway:

Human rights defenders, journalists, and medical professionals are facing intimidation, arbitrary detention, and killings, severely obstructing humanitarian efforts and independent reporting in conflict zones.

CONCLUSION: THE LEAP OF ACTION

OJAH's findings confirm a dangerous escalation of human rights violation in Ethiopia in the period from July to September 2025. The threats identified in the previous pilot period (January – June 2025) have materialized into systematic attacks, evidenced by the high percentage of unlawful killings, the use of military-grade weaponry in civilian areas. The Ethiopian government and state-aligned regional forces (regional militia and regional police force) once again stood out as the prime perpetrator of violence, accounting for a significant percentage of all documented incidents. This clearly indicates the urgency for a determined effort on the part of organizations working on human rights to put combined pressure on the government to confront impunity in Ethiopia.

Children, women, and the elderly bear the heaviest toll. Rights defenders, journalists, and health professionals continue to face intimidation, arbitrary detention, and killings, which severely undermine humanitarian operations and independent monitoring.

ROADMAP FOR JUSTICE: ACTIONABLE RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on the evidence and patterns identified in this continuous monitoring project, OJAH presents the following urgent recommendations for all stakeholders:

TO HUMAN RIGHTS ADVOCACY ORGANIZATIONS AND CIVIL SOCIETY

1. **Unify and Coordinate Actions of Human Rights Defenders:** We call the attention of organizations working to bring justice and accountability in Ethiopia to the fact that their fragmented efforts are hindering results. OJAH proposes to take the initiative to lead this coordination and calls upon all parties involved to join arms with it in forming a *Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations* outside the radius of the government control to build a unified and effective front for justice and accountability in Ethiopia.

2. **Victim-Centered Justice:** The Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations should advocate for a comprehensive transitional justice process that is victim-centered, inclusive, and independently monitored, ensuring that any framework addresses truth-telling, reparations, and preventing future violence as top priorities.
3. **Search for and Apply all Potential Alternate Avenues to Guarantee Justice and Accountability:** The Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations should put pressure on the Ethiopian government for the immediate enactment of the National Transitional Justice Mechanism and also explore other alternative avenues to guarantee justice and accountability.

TO THE INTERNATIONAL COMMUNITY (POLICY MAKERS & DIPLOMATIC BODIES)

4. **Technical and Financial Support towards Unity among Human Rights Defenders:** OJAH calls upon international partners to extend technical and financial support to expedite the process of the formation of a Consortium of Ethiopian Human Rights Organizations outside the radar of the government to spearhead a unified force against impunity in Ethiopia.
5. **Conditioned Engagement:** Impose robust, targeted sanctions on individuals and entities responsible for grave violations in Ethiopia and condition all non-humanitarian aid and diplomatic engagement on verifiable, substantive improvements in human rights protection.

TO ETHIOPIAN JUSTICE AND SECURITY INSTITUTIONS AND PERPETRATORS OF VIOLENCE

6. **Cessation of Complicity:** We demand an immediate, internal and independent investigation into the documented institutional failure to intervene in the protection of civilians. Commanders of forces present during documented incidents of inaction must be held accountable.
7. **End Unlawful Detention and Ensure Due Process:** OJAH demand an immediate release of all unlawfully detained individuals in Ethiopia and insist on detention being conducted strictly in accordance with the law, guaranteeing prompt review by an independent authority, and ensuring access to legal support and family communication.
8. **Call for Protection for Defenders of Human Rights in Ethiopia:** We demand that the Ethiopian government end harassment, threats, and targeting human rights defenders, journalists, and medical staff for their efforts to ensure justice and accountability.
9. **Call to stop violence:** We demand that the Ethiopian government and all parties involved, including Tigray Regional Forces/Police; Fano Militants; Eritrean Defense Forces; and armed individuals/groups stop violating human rights.

The Organization for Justice and Accountability in the Horn of Africa (OJAH) is an independent and impartial organization dedicated to promoting justice and accountability in the region through evidence collection and preservation. Our mission is to deter war crimes, crimes against humanity, conflict-related sexual violence, and other human rights abuses across the Greater Horn of Africa. We achieve this by conducting investigations, preserving and analyzing materials, documentation, fostering an environment conducive to justice and accountability, and supporting international actors and efforts in these areas.

